

Teotihuacán

In the broad San Juan valley to the northeast of modern-day Mexico City, at over 2,000 metres (7,000 ft) above sea level, stand the remains of Teotihuacán, once the largest and most powerful city in the pre-Columbian Americas. Who founded it, and when, remains something of a mystery, but its zenith was c.150 BCE–750 CE; the Aztec culture that arose more than a thousand years later considered Teotihuacán a sacred site and used ideas from its architecture for their own structures.

Organized in a strict grid, Teotihuacán once covered an area of up to 36 square kilometres (14 square miles). At its heart is a long, straight central avenue that the Aztecs called the Avenue of the Dead because the mounds lining its sides looked like tombs. The city's pyramids, incorporating ziggurat-style platforms, include the Pyramid of the Moon (c.250 CE) and Pyramid of the Sun (c.200 CE). The latter, standing over 61 metres (200 ft) high, was originally plastered and painted red, and chambers buried deep beneath it were possibly the site of ancient creation rituals.

